

Sean Pauley

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Education

Ph.D. in Mass Communication (May 2028)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

Doctoral Minor in African American Studies

Advisor: Michael Wagner

M.A. in Journalism and Mass Communication (May 2024)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

Thesis: *Fragmented Ideology: How Partisan Opinion Leaders Bundle Economic Issues*

Advisor: Michael Wagner

B.A. in New Media Studies (May 2022)

Alma College

Minor in Political Science

Research Experience

Center for Communication and Civic Renewal (2023-2026)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

- Led the survey integration and distribution efforts behind the group's Chime In project, a randomized controlled trial using Meta ads to address vaccine hesitancy
- Developed Bayesian models for analyzing changes in media consumption
- Created and managed a GitHub organization for the center's programming projects and led onboarding workshops to facilitate the transition to GitHub
- Worked with the Identity and Consumption subgroup to create code that systematically cleaned a 95 million row dataset from MRI-Simmons for usage in a variety of projects
- Created batteries of questions to assess economic attitudes and conditions in the 2022 and 2024 surveys

Gamer Group (2023-2026)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

- Co-founded a student-led research group on communication and video games under Dr. Karyn Riddle's supervision
- Designed and administered a survey to assess respondents' motivations for playing different games and their perceptions of community norms
- Developed web-based experimental methods to assess behavioral responses to manipulations in game design

Research Forward Group (2025-2026)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

- Managed the data surrounding a project led by Dr. Dhavan Shah and Dr. Timothy Rogers to use large language models to predict responses to public opinion polls
- Created an algorithm for sampling relevant partisan news headlines to feed it to the large language model

Computational Approaches and Message Effects Group (2025-2026)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

- Managed the data surrounding an analysis of media consumption and health-related outcomes organized by Dr. Sijia Yang

Research Work with Dr. Michael Wagner (2023-2026)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

- Developed tools for collecting and analyzing local television news data related to AI data centers in the United States
- Collected around 100,000 news articles and transcripts related to inflation, unemployment and recession
- Used structural topic modeling to assess coverage themes

Project DATA (Summer 2023)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

- Worked with Dr. Young Mie Kim to analyze social media ads and survey responses by modeling political attitudes conditioned on ad exposure categories
- Used the University of Wisconsin–Madison's Center for High Throughput Computing to analyze and process massive datasets of social media posts

Publications

Pauley, S., Dubree, W., & Woods, B. E. (2026). Prepare to DEI: Addressing GamerGate through political opinions and cultural values in gaming communities. *Psychology of Popular Media*. <https://doi.org/10.1037/ppm0000672>

Pauley, S. (2025). Picking up the call for reparations: News coverage following three catalysts.

Conference Papers

Pauley, S., Edgerly, S., Mak, M. K. F., Mine, N., Yang, E., Shan, L., & Lee, N. (June 2026). *Advances in measuring media repertoires: Modeling decisions' effects on repertoire structure and interpretation*. Presented at the International Communication Association Conference. Cape Town, South Africa.

Edgerly, S., **Pauley, S.**, Lee, N., & Wagner, M. (June 2026). *Subtle, but seismic: Change and continuity in American news consumption repertoires, 2000-2020*. Presented at the International Communication Association Conference. Cape Town, South Africa.

Sun, L., Li, Z., Pendyala, V., Suh, Y. J., Chuang, Y. S., **Pauley, S.**, Yang, S., Rogers, T., & Shah, D. (June 2026). *Designing digital twins for AI opinion simulation: How prompt framing and depth drive predictive fidelity*. Presented at the International Communication Association Conference. Cape Town, South Africa.

Zhang, T. H., Cao, X., **Pauley, S.**, Garetto, A., Abril, E. P., & Yang, S. (April 2026). *Cultivation of consumption: An observational causal analysis of adult animated comedy viewing and sugar-sweetened beverage consumption*. Presented at the Kentucky Conference on Health Communication. Lexington, KY.

Abril, E. P., **Pauley, S.**, & Garetto, A. (November 2025). *Sampling episodes in popular series: The Goldilocks approach*. Presented at the Midwest Association for Public Opinion Research Conference. Chicago, IL.

Pauley, S., Dubree, W., & Woods, B. E. (June 2025). *Prepare to DEI: Addressing GamerGate through political opinions and cultural values in gaming communities*. Presented at the International Communication Association Conference. Denver, CO.

Wells, C., Friedland, L., Shah, D., Cramer, K., Lee, N., Edgerly, S., Shan, L., & **Pauley, S.** (June 2025). *How media consumption patterns are distributed across American social classes: Implications for political opinion and engagement*. Presented at the Weizenbaum Conference. Berlin, Germany.

Pauley, S. (August 2024). *Picking up the call for reparations: News media coverage following The Black Lives Matter protests*. Presented at the AEJMC Conference. Philadelphia, PA.

Kim, J., **Pauley, S.**, & Wagner, M. (November 2023). *Does national identity help or harm*

America? The interplay of national and party identities on partisan animosity and immigrant attitudes. Presented at the Midwest Political Science Association Conference. Chicago, IL.

Pauley, S., & Maki, J. (August 2023). *Podcast politics: How ideological media construct issue-party relationships.* Presented at the APSA Political Communication Preconference. Los Angeles, CA.

Pauley, S. (November 2020). *Cast from the commonwealth: Examining Pyre's representation of intellectual disability.* Presented at the National Communication Association Game Studies Preconference. Indianapolis, IN.

Other Presentations

Pauley, S. (March 2026). *Conceptualizing reparations in surveys: Analyzing issue framing and its implications.* Presented at Communication Crossroads. Madison, WI.

Pauley, S., Woods, B., & Dubree, W. (March 2026). *Negotiating viability: Examining deliberation, balance, and item decisions in Deadlock.* Presented at Communication Crossroads. Madison, WI.

Pauley, S. (February 2026). *Constructing reparations: How newspapers and polls shape public understanding.* Presented at the African American Studies Symposium. Madison, WI.

Pauley, S., Dubree, W., & Woods, B. (March 2025). *Prepare to DEI: Addressing GamerGate through political opinions and cultural values in gaming communities.* Presented at Communication Crossroads. Madison, WI.

Pauley, S. (March 2025). *Measuring reparations attitudes: New approaches to questionnaire design.* Presented at Communication Crossroads. Madison, WI.

Pauley, S. (March 2024). *Fragmented ideology: How partisan opinion leaders bundle economic issues.* Presented at Communication Crossroads. Madison, WI.

Instructional Experience

Lead Teaching Assistant, J202: Mass Media Practices (2023-2024)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

- Created six web-based interactive modules to teach writing concepts

- Ran weekly staff meetings preparing the eight TAs for their lab sections
- Managed the six-credit course's Canvas page
- Developed lesson plans and teaching materials
- Taught web development skills for WordPress

Teaching Assistant, J202: Mass Media Practices (2022-2023)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

- Taught journalism and strategic communication skills
- Helped students develop skills with Adobe Premiere and Audition

Lead Writing Consultant (2021-2022)

Alma College Writing Center

- Offered feedback on student papers and explained writing concepts
- Developed student resources and handouts

Supplemental Instruction Leader, Programming with Data (Winter 2022)

Alma College

- Taught sessions on Python and spreadsheets software
- Helped students develop quantitative reasoning

Supplemental Instruction Leader, Political Science Statistics (Winter 2022)

Alma College

- Helped students learn Microsoft Excel and data analysis
- Taught students quantitative skills for political science research

Grant Projects

Game Developer (2021-2023)

Grand Rapids Public Museum, Grand Rapids, MI

National Endowment for the Humanities, "River of Time," \$100,000

- Worked as a solo developer to design and program a location-based, augmented reality, web game that allows players to explore Grand Rapids history throughout the city
- Developed ArcGIS-based geolocation infrastructure
- Worked with scholars to showcase indigenous history around the Grand River
- Integrated game databases with the museum collections, built data structures for museum artifacts and collections and automated the processing of collections data

Service Activities

Presenter, Computational Communication Cooperative (Fall 2024)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

- Led a session teaching graduate students about cloud computing through UW-Madison's Center for High Throughput Computing

Presenter, Computational Communication Cooperative (Fall 2023)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

- Led a session teaching graduate students about JavaScript integration in Qualtrics and how to design dynamic survey questions with JavaScript and HTML
- Led a second session about using GitHub for collaborative coding projects

Grad Resource Fair (Summer 2023)

University of Wisconsin – Madison

- Promoted the research and professional programs for the School of Journalism and Mass Communication to prospective students

Awards

Second Place Graduate Student Paper, UW–Madison Department of African American Studies (2026)

Top Student Paper, AEJMC Political Communication Division (2024)

Teaching Excellence Award, UW–Madison School of Journalism and Mass Communication (2024)
